

4.1 Layers

Using layers, you can combine multiple images, or cut out parts of images and place them in different layers. Let's take an example:

Now what we do is use the Lasso tool to cut out the parts we need, place them all on different layers in a new document, and voila!

Here, we used five layers: the background (chimney), a cut-out of the guy who's pointing, another of the parachuting skydiver, the text layer (of course), and a little more complex cut-out of the part of the skydiver that's entered the smoke. We got that effect by reducing the opacity of the fifth layer that contains the complex cut-out of the skydiver!

This may seem hard, but after you're done with this book you'll understand how easy what we just did is. Making a composite image using layers, as in this case, should take you no more than a few minutes—it took us just four minutes to make this image!

4.2 Adding And Deleting Layers

The most basic steps to working with layers are adding and deleting them. Very often, when you use the text tool, for instance, you inadvertently click on the canvas, and a new layer is formed. Now, if you don't delete these layers, you're going to end up with a *lot* of useless layers bloating the size of your image. To delete a layer, just right-click on its name and select Delete Layer. Alternatively, you can also just left-click on it and then left-click on the little trash can icon in the bottom right of the Layers palette.

When it comes to adding a layer, there are many ways to go about it. Let's say you want to add a layer for text. All you need to do is select the text tool by pressing [T] or by clicking on the "T" in the toolbar and then clicking on the canvas. A new layer is formed.